Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S.

When we were in the food stamps program, we used to buy meat eggs, flour, and vegetables- essentially everything we needed. However, now that we no longer have food stamps, we are only buying vegetables

a. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months, can you tell me more about that?

Unfortunately, it didn't work out I was trying to find a decent job that offered good pay. Both my daughter and my wife have applied at places like Costco, Walmart, and WinCo, which are all part of a referral service that helps you get registered and find jobs. We went there hoping they could help us find work, but they were unable to assist us. The main problem was our lack of language skills, which made it very difficult. If we didn't have a language barrier perhaps, we would have been accepted in some position.

We are a family of six, and we have a son who is also unemployed. He has applied for jobs several times but has not been successful. My wife, our children, and I have all applied for good jobs at least to be able to buy food and other necessities. However, in the job we currently have, the income is only enough to cover expenses like fuel, insurance, rent, and loans of OIM, as well as the cast of mobile sim card bills.

b. Can you explain what you did to find help with food and if that worked?

IRC only provided us with some raw or cooked food a few times over four months, and that assistance was not sufficient. However, the food stamps helped us much during that time.

c. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?

IRC didn't provide us with much help they only sent someone to our home to show us how to use the bus and navigate the system until we learned. They provided us with a bus card for about 8 months, and my wife, son, and daughter attended English class downtown. Gradually, they learned a lot my other daughter, who is now 18 years old, is in the 10 grade. We are grateful to God for everything. Our nights turn into days, and I am trying to get a car to work with Uber. My son is also planning to go to the university and also work. We are searching for a good job both for me and my wife. Currently, my son has started working with Uber Food for three days.

What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?

The most helpful thing they did for us was to provide us with housing assistance and bring us raw. Food for a while. They also showed us how to use the bus system, guiding us on how to get around

d. Can you tell me when food became a problem?

When the food stamps were cut off many problems began to arise. We called the DWS several times, but they didn't reinstate our benefits due to our reported income. If you don't work, how can you pay for rent? There is a constant fear of being evicted naturally, if you cannot pay rent, you risk getting thrown out of your home, and it also becomes difficult to cover bills for gas, electricity, insurance, and other expenses.

i. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months. Can you tell me why you have not used food assistance programs during these times?

We rely on government food assistance, and we go to places where help is provided, such as schools run by Arab organizations. We had food stamps, we would not need to seek help often, but now that we don't have them, we depend on other forms of assistance. However, there are some items we cannot use from aid programs due to restrictions, for instance, we can only use milk and canned goods. We used to buy items like Tomatoes, but now we can't even afford that. Our caseworker mentioned that there are various food assistance programs, but they didn't provide us with addresses or details; they only said that such help exists. Additionally, we faced issues with transportation. I have a car, but it is challenging to manage everyone's needs. I must drop off my wife, then my daughter, and then another daughter at school, and after that, I go to my job. Once night falls, I pick them up again and return home around 8 pm.

ii. Can you explain your experiences with applying for food programs since you graduated from

The government assistance that friends recommended to us is what we received. I go in the morning after I drop my daughter off at school because the others cannot go due to their responsibilities, so I go to collect the aid alone. While we do receive some meat, it is not halal, and the burgers are also not halal; we can only use the fish, we use the milk, and some of the cakes if they have however, the food stamps have been cut off, and we are managing with what we have, but it is very difficult to purchase dry bread and flour, which are daily necessities. We also cannot afford rice. When we had food stamps, we could not buy these things.

e. You indicated that in the last 12 months, you often/always worried that the food you were able to eat would hurt your health and well-being, can you tell me more?

The meat we receive is frozen, and the burgers are also frozen. Some of the other items, like popcorn canned, and meat are not usable. The fruits we get are sometimes grapes, peaches, or apples and we occasionally have some vegetables. However, we are concerned that the other items we use might be harmful to our health because we do not understand them.

2. Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.

We prefer lamb. Goat, beef and we also use chicken. We consume vegetables like okra, zucchini cauliflower, eggplant, and potatoes as well as Bolani.

a. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?

Bolani is very important to us, and I really soup meat. My wife and I love it a lot.

b. Where do you get your vegetables and cultural foods from?

Currently, we are recovering help from Arab organizations, another program from school whose names I cannot remember we get vegetables from there, and WinCo.

c. How does/did <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> help you with finding foods from your culture?

In our culture, we received help when we were in another house and had just moved in the US. They brought us eggplant, cauliflower, and cucumbers, when we were in west Jordan, they didn't show us a place where we could get these items.

Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)

READ TO PARTICIPANT: This is the last section of our interview, and I would like to ask your suggestions on how to improve food security among refugees.

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?

The problem is that when we have a high income, the food stamps get cut off. If my wife and I don't work, it will become active again. If I cannot find a good job, I will start doing Uber and I will ask my friends how to start.

2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?

If they are unemployed, they can reapply at DWS for food stamps to receive assistance again.

3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?

It is very difficult because several people are uneducated. If they go to the IRC or DWS, they might not be able to communicate properly and may struggle with the transition when applying. All of this is based on work and income; food stamps depend on that as well.

4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

Here, we are much happier than in Afghanistan. Everything is available; there is education and work, and everyone can take care of their lives and move forward in their own way. My daughter works, and my other daughter also striving to find a job. I, too, along with my daughter and wife, often feel tired and headache after work. Our Afghan community faces many challenges, primarily due to language barriers is fundamental problems; that affect everything. My son has applied to several places, but since coming here, he has not studied well. In Afghanistan there was nothing, and the situation is dire. Now, we are pleased to be here, and

we have built a life, hoping to find better work four of us are working, but we earn little money, which means we cannot afford to buy vegetables and meats; we are deprived of these things.